SAMPLE

Greetings and Etiquette: The Manners of the Believer

Greetings and Etiquette in the Quran

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Introduction

The Quran is not merely a book of theology but a book of manners. From the greeting that one person offers to another, to the way one enters a home, to the manner of conversation and eating, the Quran provides guidance for the everyday interactions that constitute human social life. The guidance is not arbitrary but is rooted in a coherent understanding of the human being as a creation of Allah who is in relationship with other creations of Allah. The manners that the Quran prescribes are the expression of respect: respect for Allah, respect for other human beings, respect for the spaces that people inhabit, and respect for the relationships that bind people together. The manners are the outward expression of the inward faith, and the expression is what makes faith visible in the daily life of the believer. This book examines the Quranic guidance for greetings and etiquette, exploring the key verses, the prophetic tradition, and the lessons that emerge from the Quranic framework for social interaction. The book is part of the Life in the Quran sub-series of the NurOne master series by Aira Aurora. The approach is through the Quranic text, supplemented by authentic prophetic tradition, and avoids speculation beyond what the sources provide. The goal is to present the Quranic guidance for everyday interactions with clarity, fidelity, and depth.

Chapter 1: The Islamic Greeting (Salam)

The Quran establishes the Islamic greeting as a divine instruction: "And when you are greeted with a greeting, greet with a better one or return it. Indeed, Allah is ever, over all things, an Accountant" (4:86). The verse establishes three principles: the greeting must be returned, the return must be equal or better, and Allah is the accounter of the exchange. The greeting in question is the salam - "peace be upon you" (as-salamu alaykum) - and the return must be at least "and upon you be peace" (wa alaykum as-salam) and may be enhanced with additional words of blessing.

The principle of returning the greeting with a better one is significant because it establishes a culture of escalation in goodness. The person who is greeted with "peace be upon you" may respond with "and upon you be peace and the mercy of Allah" (wa alaykum as-salam wa rahmatullah), and the person who receives this may respond with an additional "and His blessings" (wa barakatuhu). The escalation is not competitive but cooperative - each person adds to the greeting, and the addition produces a chain of blessings that elevates the exchange from a mere formality to a genuine expression of mutual good will.

The word salam is from the same root as Islam (s-l-m), which means peace, safety, and submission. The greeting "as-salamu alaykum" means "peace be upon you" and is both a prayer (asking Allah for peace for the other person) and a statement (affirming that the other person is safe from the speaker). The dual function - prayer and statement - is significant because it makes the greeting both a spiritual act and a social one. The person who offers the salam is praying for the other person's peace and is also declaring that the other person has nothing to fear from them.

The meaning of salam as safety is particularly important in the context of pre-Islamic Arabia, where the greeting was a matter of survival. The person who offered salam was declaring that the other person was safe from them - that they would not harm them. The Islamic tradition maintained this meaning and elevated it: the Muslim who offers salam is declaring that the other Muslim is safe from them, not just physically but spiritually and socially. The safety is the foundation of the trust that binds the community, and the greeting is the daily renewal of the trust.

The Prophet is reported to have said: "The one who is riding should greet the one who is walking, the one who is walking should greet the one who is sitting, and the smaller group should greet the larger group." The hadith establishes a hierarchy of greeting that is based on consideration for the other person. The person who is in the more comfortable position (riding rather than walking, sitting rather than standing) is the one who should initiate the greeting, because the person in the less comfortable position has less capacity to initiate. The hierarchy is not about superiority but about consideration - the person who has more ease should be the one who makes the effort.

The priority of the greeting also extends to the relationship between the greeting and other acts. The Prophet is reported to have said that the greeting should precede any conversation. The person who approaches another person should greet them first and then begin the conversation. The greeting is the foundation of the interaction, and the foundation must be laid before the structure is built. The greeting that precedes the conversation establishes the tone: the interaction that begins with peace is the interaction that is oriented toward good.

The Prophet is reported to have said: "There are six rights of a Muslim over another Muslim." Among them: "When you meet him, greet him with salam." The greeting is not optional but is a right that one Muslim has over another. The right is the basis of the communal bond - the community that greets each other is the community that maintains the bonds of brotherhood, and the greeting is the daily expression of the bond. The person who withholds the greeting without cause is the person who has weakened the bond, and the weakening is the failure of the communal obligation.

The greeting as a right also means that the greeting should not be withheld for petty reasons. The person who is angry with another Muslim should still greet them, because the greeting is not about the personal relationship but about the communal bond. The greeting that is offered despite anger is the greeting that is the strongest, because it is the greeting that has overcome the ego's resistance and has placed the communal bond above the personal grievance. The Prophet is reported to have said: "You will not enter Paradise until you believe, and you will not believe until you love one another. Shall I tell you something that will make you love one another? Spread the salam among you."